

outnumbered the numbers touted by most of our competitors by a long shot, as IT departments have had free access to all of our technologies, and have keenly implemented internal POCs and begun initial adoption without worrying about procurements first."

She further says that the open source model also helps in reducing the cost of the sale, as most sales communications happen with potential customers who are already using the company's open source edition and are transitioning to a model that comes with commercial support. On the development front, open source has helped the company in a multitude of ways.

"We believe some of the greatest innovations in the technology front are happening in the open source ecosystem, and while proprietary software are compelled to look at most innovations as competition, the open source model provides for a mutually beneficial ecosystem that enables us to integrate the best-of-breed innovations into our offering. It has also helped us in recruiting some of the most passionate and smart technologists in the industry from across the world," reveals Romasha.

Cyn.in vs proprietary competitors

"Our highest investment in Cyn.in over the last year has been towards making it simple, usable and adaptable. Since we distribute, sell and support Cyn.in to businesses across the globe, over the Internet, we have had to make sure that though Cyn.in is a large enterprise software, it can as easily be set up, deployed and adopted as a desktop application. To top all of this, our pricing model is competitive enough, making the TCO of Cyn.in 80 per cent lower compared to most of our competition," quips Romasha.

She adds, "Along with a free (of cost) open source edition, Cyn.in is also available as a supported enterprise edition, as well as a hosted and managed SaaS (software as a service) offering. Most organisations using Cyn.in actively for critical operations within their businesses prefer to buy commercial support for Cyn.in. Most small- to mid-sized businesses prefer to go with the SaaS option to avoid infrastructure and maintenance expenses. Beyond our off-the-shelf commercial offerings, we provide customisation and custom integration to ERPs/CRMs for our large customers, along with various other services like customised training, information architecture consulting, customised documentation and manuals around a customer's business processes, etc."

The market for Cyn.in

Fundamentally, any knowledge-centric business or organisation that depends heavily on e-mail and digital documents for their business operations would require a product like Cyn.in. However, the company says its current market focus is towards mid- to large-sized businesses.

"We have broad customer diversity, ranging from Fortune 500 companies with over 40,000 users to small training institutes with 10 users. We have customers across

Cyn.in: The innovative edge

Contextual discussions: Cyn.in provides for rapid, threaded discussions across all its applications, enabling its users to discuss files, wiki documents, video and audio content, Web bookmarks, or any kind of content added to the system. Contextual discussions in Cyn.in form the heart of collaboration.

Activity stream: Though now a common concept thanks to the new Facebook, the company claims Cyn.in was the first application to create a cross-application, cross-context stream of live information. In its current avatar, the activity stream sports multi-faceted filtering of content, making it an indispensable tool for users who want to be updated at all times, locate any information and focus only on what is relevant to them.

IM-style desktop-based contextual discussions: The activity stream and contextual discussions are fused into a cross-platform desktop client that provides an instant-messaging-like experience to users, while maintaining context to the conversations and messages.

Tightly unified, extensible applications: Though the content applications in Cyn.in may share the branding and basic concepts of blogs, wikis and document management systems, their capabilities are strongly enhanced by each other and they are tightly coupled at various points.

Fine-grained security and access control: Unlike most Web 2.0/Enterprise2.0 applications out there, Cyn.in addresses enterprise information security concerns and provides for a strong role-based security model at granular levels, making it well suited for compliance conscious enterprises.

Software appliance-based rapid deployment: Cyn.in is distributed pre-bundled with its own application server, database server and a hardened operating system, making it a completely self-sufficient software appliance. It does not have any external dependencies apart from server hardware. This allows Cyn.in to be set up in minutes, and commercially supported customers are provided with additional benefits of remote support and troubleshooting, as well as live updates that ensure continuity and uptime.

the globe, from the US, Europe, the Middle East, Asia and even Africa. We have a strong close-knit community around Cyn.in, thanks to the Plone community and are scheduled to invest in growing the community publicly, beyond the Python/Plone circles." 

By Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.